

SPIRITUAL AUTHORITY

Brown denotes instructions to technician

Blue denotes PPT slide

TEXT: Romans 13:1-7 (NKJV) *“Let every soul be subject to the governing authorities. For there is no authority except from God, and the authorities that exist are appointed by God. ² Therefore whoever resists the authority resists the ordinance of God, and those who resist will bring judgment on themselves. ³ For rulers are not a terror to good works, but to evil. Do you want to be unafraid of the authority? Do what is good, and you will have praise from the same. ⁴ For he is God’s minister to you for good. But if you do evil, be afraid; for he does not bear the sword in vain; for he is God’s minister, an avenger to execute wrath on him who practices evil. ⁵ Therefore you must be subject, not only because of wrath but also for*

conscience' sake. ⁶ For because of this you also pay taxes, for they are God's ministers attending continually to this very thing. ⁷ Render therefore to all their due: taxes to whom taxes are due, customs to whom customs, fear to whom fear, honor to whom honor."

INTRO: Tonight, we begin a series of four lessons on Spiritual Authority. There can be no authority, spiritual or otherwise, without submission on the part of those who are being led by an authority. For starters, all of us must be under the authority of God but we also must place ourselves under the authority to a human being. Submission to authority must be transacted except when such submission would cause us to violate a biblical mandate. (Explain what that is and is not)

Spiritual principles highlighted in our text include: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- **Every person must be subject to governing authorities...** (This means to be in obedience to)
- **All authority is appointed by God...** (There are times that God allows for ungodly rulership because of the sin of the people – Israel)
- **Anyone who resist authority resist the government of God...**
- **Those in authority are not a threat to those who do good but to those who do evil...**
- **Anyone who stands against authority that has been appointed by God will reap the negative consequences of their actions...**
- **If we do good we need not fear those in authority...**
- **If we do evil, we are right to fear those in authority because both they and God have a sword that can be turned against evildoers...**

- If we do good we will receive praise from those who are in authority...
- We are to be doers of good deeds, not simply because we are afraid of the wrath of God or our authorities, but because we want to live with a good conscience...
- We are to pay honor and respect to those to whom honor is due... (We are to respect the office even when we do not respect the person who holds the office)

Please allow me to run through **a list of principles that will help to lay the foundation for this study: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Lawlessness is the spirit of antichrist and is alive and well in the world and in the church... (Lawlessness is making major decisions in our lives without consulting those who are in authority over us – People who leave a church without getting the opinion of their leaders – The spirit that drives such decisions is the spirit

of lawlessness – When a person refuses to consult spiritual authority, they become a law unto themselves, and therefore open the door in their lives and homes to the spirit of lawlessness – Antichrist - This is the same spirit that will usher in the antichrist)

- **Rebellion is usually an attitude before it is an activity...** (One can be in rebellion without saying a word or taking an action)
- **Obedience to those in authority is an expectation that God has placed upon all Christ followers...** (Many people claim to be submitted to authority but their actions say otherwise – They make life altering decisions on their own – We won't know if we are submitted until we disagree – My service to Bro. Granberry at the camp)
- **We were not born with the ability to obey, obedience is a trait that must be developed over time and through circumstances...** (A child doesn't have to

be taught to misbehave, they have to be taught to obey – As human beings, submission to authority is contrary to our nature – The lack of submission was the sin of Korah – The ground opened up and swallowed them and all those who sided with them – I seen the equivalent of that within the church)

- **Each time we come to a place of disagreement with authority, we must make a conscience decision of whether to submit or rebel...** (We are either in submission to authority or we are in rebellion – Most people would say, “*I am not rebelling, I am disagreeing.*” Look at this - The word submit means to “Stand under” but the word resist means to “Stand against” – The decision to stand under or to stand against belongs to the individual believer – The sum total of those decisions will determine whether we are UNDER authority or we are in REBELLION

against the authorities in our lives, and ultimately to God)

Unless submission causes one to violate the Word of God, we are all called upon to submit to all authority, and especially to spiritual authority. Yet, I must hasten to add, those who misuse authority will most certainly place themselves in the path of the judgement of God. The hand of the Lord is often swift and stern but sometimes it is slow and sure. One thing is for certain, it grinds to powder.

WHAT IS SPIRITUAL AUTHORITY?

All authority comes from God according to Romans 13. If all authority comes from God, **when we submit to those who have the rule over us, we are in effect submitting to God – When we resist the authority of them who have the rule over us, we are in effect resisting God!** (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) Matthew 10:40 (NASB) *"He who receives you receives Me,*

and he who receives Me receives Him who sent Me." Luke 10:16 (NASB) *"The one who listens to you listens to Me, and the one who rejects you rejects Me; and he who rejects Me rejects the One who sent Me."* Listen to what these Scriptures are pointing out: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Jesus places submission to human authority ahead of submission to Himself...
- If we receive the instructions of a delegated spiritual authority, we are receiving the words of Jesus... (Next week Susan will teach about the three kinds of authority: Delegated authority, designated authority and direct authority)
- If we receive the instruction of a delegated authority, we are not only receiving the words of Jesus, we are receiving the words of God...
- If we reject the instructions of a delegated spiritual authority, we are rejecting the

instructions of Jesus and ultimately of God...

When we speak of spiritual authority, we are speaking of those that God has chosen to place over us in the context of His church. **Hebrews 13:17** (KJV) *“Obey them that have the rule over you, and submit yourselves: for they watch for your souls, as they that must give account, that they may do it with joy, and not with grief: for that is unprofitable for you.”*

Look at what is being said here: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- **Obey spiritual authority...** (Believe them – Have confidence in them)
- **Spiritual authority is to rule over us...** (the word “*rule*” here possesses the connotation of a governor or judge – In other words, spiritual authority is to have the same kind of weight a governor or judge would have over our lives – they have the final say!)

- **We are to submit ourselves to spiritual authority...** (The word submit here literally means to surrender to them)
- **Our spiritual authorities will give an account for us...** (On judgment day, a spiritual authority will not have weight in whether a person is saved or lost, but they will have influence in the reward a person will receive)
- **We must live a life of submission to spiritual authority so that when they are called upon to give an account for us, they may do it with joy and not with sorrow...**
- **A spiritual authority giving a good report on our behalf delivers great reward for us...** (*“You have been faithful over a few things, I will make you ruler over many things.”*)
- **A spiritual authority giving a bad report on our behalf will have devastating results...** (It is after the Judgment Seat of Christ that all tears are wiped away from our eyes)

When choosing a spiritual authority, we must be careful because everything flows down from headship. I want to always make sure that those I place myself under are doing more than I am, because all things flow down in the spiritual realm. **(END OF LESSON ONE)**

This is what spiritual authority looks like in the church: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- **Jesus is the shepherd and head of the church...**
- **The Pastor is the under-shepherd and human authority of the church...**
(Revelation – Jesus addressed the Angels of the Church and no one else – The authority of the Pastor comes from Jesus – The authority of all other church leaders comes from the Pastor)
- **The Board is chosen by the church to assist the pastor to take care of the temporal matters of the church...**
(Deacons - The Board is to be submitted to)

the pastor, not the other way around – The board should be taking things off the pastor’s plate, not adding things to it – They are to be implementers of the vision)

- **The people are to be submitted to Jesus and to the Pastor...** (EVERYONE needs a pastor – Discuss people calling someone pastor but not consulting them before making major decisions)

How we react to human authority is how we are reacting to the authority of God. We cannot rebel against human authority and claim to be submitted to God. This same principle is exhibited in how we act and react to each other.

1 John 4:20 (NKJV) *“If someone says, “I love God,” and hates his brother, he is a liar; for he who does not love his brother whom he has seen, how can he love God whom he has not seen?”*

I am convinced that there are many things we cannot access in the Kingdom of God because

we either do not understand spiritual authority, or, we refuse to submit to spiritual authority. (I once prayed, “*God, I love you, but I don’t like your kids very much!*” – If you don’t like my children and grandchildren then I don’t like you)

When can we resist a spiritual authority? When their commands and demands violate a Scriptural principle. Obedience to spiritual authority is a directive from God to us, the Bible is the filter.

Look with me at the story of the Centurion.

Matthew 8:7-10 (NASB) “*Jesus *said to him, "I will come and heal him." (8) But the centurion said, "Lord, I am not worthy for You to come under my roof, but just say the word, and my servant will be healed. (9) For I also am a man under authority, with soldiers under me; and I say to this one, 'Go!' and he goes, and to another, 'Come!' and he comes, and to my slave, 'Do this!' and he does it." (10) Now when Jesus heard this, He marveled and said*

to those who were following, "Truly I say to you, I have not found such great faith with anyone in Israel." The principles taught in this passage are as follows: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The Centurion was a man UNDER authority... When a person places themselves under authority, they can easily recognize authority. Such a person knows how important it is to be in obedience to the word of one in authority. They are aware that if such compliance is not carried out with the right attitude, there are consequences that must be paid.
- Because he was a man UNDER authority, he was a man IN and OF authority... The Centurion was a man who walked in governmental authority. It made perfect sense to the Centurion that he could, by a word, direct those for whom he was responsible. When the Centurion said that he was *“a man under authority”*, he meant that

his authority came directly from the government he was serving under. He didn't have authority just because of the office he held, he had authority because he was part of the government's army. The authority of the Centurion was only good for as long as he served the government that was over him. Had he left the army, no one who reported to him would continue to be responsible to obey his commands because he would no longer have governmental authority. The same is true of the Kingdom of God. The governmental authority we exercise does not belong to us; it is on loan to us from the King of the Kingdom, to do Kingdom work. Once we are no longer UNDER authority to the King or Kingdom, we are no longer IN authority. When we attempt to EXERCISE authority without being UNDER authority we are illegitimate leaders, which plays right into the hands of Satan.

- **Jesus declared that submission to authority is the highest kind of faith**

possible... Think of this... Jesus said He hadn't found "*such great faith in all of Israel...*" More faith than the Pharisees... More faith than the Sadducees... More faith than the Scribes... More faith than the Rabbis... More faith than the multitudes... More faith than the disciples... Submission to authority is the proof of faith that the Kingdom will work in our lives.

Could it be that we do not receive from God because we are not submitted to spiritual authority? Could it be that our lack of submission is blocking our miracles?

I believe this could be exactly why many do not receive their miracle! Matthew 5:23-24 "*if you bring your gift to the altar, and there remember that your brother has something against you, ²⁴ leave your gift there before the altar, and go your way. First be reconciled to your brother, and then come and offer your gift.*"

If the Lord will reject our prayers because we are in conflict with a colleague, how much more would He reject our requests if we are in conflict with a spiritual authority?

(Alignment)

DOMINION COMES FROM SUBMISSION TO SPIRITUAL AUTHORITY

All of us were born with a natural desire to conquer and rule over things, property, and even people.

Think of Adam...

God placed Adam under His authority and gave him one commandment: "***Do not eat of the tree in the midst of the Garden.***" Then, God gave Adam spiritual authority to rule over all created things. Three things happened here:

- God delegated authority to mankind...
- Mankind received authority from God...

- The connection between the Kingdom of God and the Kingdom of man is a thing called obedience...

As long as Adam remained under spiritual authority, he had governmental authority over everything else.

Adam surrendered his right to have dominion (Rule), when he stepped out from under spiritual authority and disobeyed the Lord. At this point he lost his governmental authority over created things.

The desire to have dominion and rule has been given to us by God. But **God will only allow our dominion to go as far as our submission will take us.** Adam's rulership would only last as long as he was submitted to the purposes of God. The same God who gives authority can also retract it. (Saul – The people didn't reject Saul – God did – In fact the people supported Saul long after God rejected him)

When Adam fell, the desire to rule did not leave him, but the ability to rule was gone. In fact, from that very time his entire life was an attempt to regain his original dominion, which couldn't be completely retrieved. **The Kingdom life is one of attempting to reach the level of submission that allows us to have dominion.**

“He who is greatest in the Kingdom must be servant to all.”

Even Jesus submitted Himself to the authority of man. At twelve years old Jesus had a conflict with His parents over remaining in the Temple when He was expected to return home with them. Luke 2:51-52 (NKJV) ***“Then He went down with them and came to Nazareth, and was subject to them, but His mother kept all these things in her heart.”*** He obeyed His parents and returned to Nazareth with them at their direction. Listen to the results... (Vs. 52) ***“And Jesus increased in wisdom and stature, and in favor with God and man.”***

Won't He do it...?

It is more important to walk in obedience than to do good deeds.

CONCLUSION:

Let me conclude with **four levels of interaction with spiritual authority: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **An order...** (An order from a spiritual authority must always be followed unless it causes one to violate the Word of God – A staff member told one of our church members to lie to me – That order must be resisted)
- **Instruction...** (Instruction by a spiritual leader should be based on two things, (1) Biblical principles (2) Experience that has brought about wisdom - The instructions of a spiritual authority should be followed)
- **Advice...** (When one approaches a spiritual leader for advice, the advice of such a person should be followed – My experience at Fouke asking the Board for direction –

The advice of a spiritual leader is based on wisdom – Follow the wisdom of the spiritual leader)

- **Opinion...** (Everyone has opinions – Opinions change as time and circumstances change – As a pastor I have an opinion about what color of carpet looks good and so do you – We are both right – At least in our own eyes – The opinion of a spiritual leader is no more valuable than the opinion of any other person)

(END OF LESSON TWO)

POWER GRABBING IS A PARTNERSHIP WITH SATAN

Since the fall of Adam, the acquisition of authority is an attempt to take power, rather than waiting for it to be given. When one takes power rather than it being given, the alliance of such an activity is from Satan, rather than from God. Awaiting the gifting of authority flows out of a right relationship with God and His

authorities, a power grab is an agreement with the spirit of antichrist.

A person who awaits the moment that authority is conferred upon them operates in the spirit of Christ, a person who attempts to seize control is in alliance with the devil.

Notice, in the fall of Satan, the Bible declares that his attempt was to make himself equal to God. The spirit of antichrist says, *“I don’t have to obey rules or rulers, I know as well as anyone else how things should be done.”* This was not only the downfall of Lucifer, it is the downfall of multitudes of would be, could be, Kingdom authorities.

Isaiah 14:12-14 (NASB) ***"How you have fallen from heaven, O star of the morning, son of the dawn! You have been cut down to the earth, You who have weakened the nations! (13) "But you said in your heart, 'I will ascend to heaven; I will raise my throne above the stars of God, And I will sit on the mount of assembly***

In the recesses of the north. (14) 'I will ascend above the heights of the clouds; I will make myself like the Most High.'"

The TAKING of authority is a principle that was enacted by Satan himself, and is directly opposed to how we are to acquire and assume authority in the Kingdom of God.

I have known many people who are doctrinally correct yet align themselves with the devil in how they acquire and handle authority. The driving force behind such leadership is pride. *"Pride goes before destruction an a haughty spirit before a fall."*

The mode of operation of those who are being influenced by Satan is to stand against authority – God's authority and all authority. The prevailing winds of operation for a person who is operating in such a spirit is RESIST! (We are seeing this spirit being played out in our government right now) 1 Peter 5:5 *"God resists the proud but gives grace to the humble."*

Please remember, if we stand against authority, God will stand against us. **If we want to walk in authority, influence and power we must learn to stand under authority rather than standing against authority.**

Jesus took this position with regard to the plan of salvation and the will of His Father.

Philippians 2:5-8 (NASB) *“Have this attitude in yourselves which was also in Christ Jesus, (6) who, although He existed in the form of God, did not regard equality with God a thing to be grasped, (7) but emptied Himself, taking the form of a bond-servant, and being made in the likeness of men. (8) Being found in appearance as a man, He humbled Himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross.”* If Jesus walked in humility rather than pride how much more should we?

Nadab and Abihu are great examples of taking authority rather than awaiting authority to be conferred: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- **Nadab and Abihu were the sons of Aaron...** (Aaron was the High Priest)
- **They offered an unauthorized sacrifice upon the altar...** (They had watched their father offer such offerings hundreds of times – They were familiar)
- **They believed they were as capable of offering sacrifices as was their father...** (But they were not authorized to do so)
- **Only Aaron had been authorized by God to offer such a sacrifice...** (The authority to do so could not come from Aaron or his sons – Such authorization was the sole responsibility of the Lord)

Leviticus 10:1-2 (NASB) *“Now Nadab and Abihu, the sons of Aaron, took their respective firepans, and after putting fire in them, placed incense on it and offered strange fire before the LORD, which He had not commanded them. (2) And fire came out from the presence of the LORD and consumed them, and they died before the LORD.”* Nadab and Abihu

offered strange fire without Aaron's authorization and God consumed them with fire. What we sow against spiritual authority we will reap. What we sow favorably in the field of a spiritual authority we will reap.

The sin of Nadab and Abihu is related to the sin of Korah, Dathan, Abiram, and their followers. The sin of these men was an attempt to place themselves on the same level as Moses saying, ***"We are as capable of making these decisions as you are."*** The Lord caused the ground to open up and swallow these men along with 14,700 of their followers. It is a dangerous thing to follow a person, who is in rebellion against a spiritual authority, no matter how influential they are.

These men and their followers felt they were as capable of making decisions as was the delegated leaders that God had assigned over them. This is the sin of the modern-day church! **Everything spiritual has become so commonplace that everyone is becoming a**

law unto themselves. This sin is bringing about anarchy in the Kingdom.

While many believers would never usurp the authority of those in authority, they feel completely comfortable to sit around and criticize the decisions of those who are in authority. This also is rebellion against authority and therefore is an alliance with Satan. ***“He who judges a matter without knowing all the facts is a fool.”*** (Monday morning quarterbacks in the church)

Listen to this: **Numbers 12:1-2** (NASB) ***“Then Miriam and Aaron spoke against Moses because of the Cushite woman whom he had married (for he had married a Cushite woman); (2) and they said, “Has the LORD indeed spoken only through Moses? Has He not spoken through us as well?” And the LORD heard it.”*** Moses married outside his race which garnered the criticism of Aaron and Miriam (His brother and sister – Usually the

criticism comes from the most unlikely source).

Look at the turn of events here:

- **Moses married outside his race...**
- **God never took a side on the issue of the marriage...**
- **God heard the grumbling against leadership from behind the scenes...**
- **The presence of God left the tent of meeting...**
- **Miriam contracted leprosy which lasted seven days...**
- **Aaron did not become the successor of Moses, Joshua did...** (He was Moses brother, spokesman, and High Priest - Could his premature death and failure to move up be the result of his criticism of his leader?)

A PROPER RESPONSE TO AUTHORITY

There are three kinds of authority:

- **Direct authority...**
- **Delegated authority...**

- **Designated authority...**

(Susan will teach on this)

One of the things we have learned in this study is that God is the authority of all, but He assigns authority to individuals, and **one cannot say we are submitted to God without submitting to the authorities He has appointed**. One cannot reject God's representative on the one hand, and receive God on the other.

Make no mistake about it, God protects the authorities that He appoints:

- 10 times the children of Israel tempted God...
- 5 times they disbelieved Him...
- Yet God forgave them and allowed them to continue serving him...

When the people rebelled against authority the judgment of God was oftentimes swift and stern and at other times it was slow and sure. one may resist authority and get by temporarily, but one

thing is for certain, God always judges resistance of authority.

King David seemed to understand the principle of proper alignment with authority. Even though Saul, the first King of Israel had sinned against the Lord and had been rejected by the Lord, David refused to turn his hand against him. Remember, David had already been anointed by Samuel to be Saul's successor. **David knew the value of authority being conferred and the devastating results of power being taken.**

While David patiently waited his turn at the throne, Saul hunted him like a common criminal. The hatred of Saul toward David, and the meek attitude with which David dealt with Saul, caused Saul to want to kill David.

In 1 Samuel 24:3-7 (NASB) we are permitted to observe the actions of David toward Saul. ***“He came to the sheepfolds on the way, where there was a cave; and Saul went in to relieve himself. Now David and his men were sitting in the***

inner recesses of the cave. (4) The men of David said to him, "Behold, this is the day of which the LORD said to you, 'Behold; I am about to give your enemy into your hand, and you shall do to him as it seems good to you.'" Then David arose and cut off the edge of Saul's robe secretly. (5) It came about afterward that David's conscience bothered him because he had cut off the edge of Saul's robe. (6) So he said to his men, "Far be it from me because of the LORD that I should do this thing to my lord, the LORD'S anointed, to stretch out my hand against him, since he is the LORD'S anointed." (7) David persuaded his men with these words and did not allow them to rise up against Saul. And Saul arose, left the cave, and went on his way."

David refused to act in rebellion. He refused to raise his hand against the Lord's anointed. Even cutting off the hem of the skirt caused guilt. David passed the submission test – But not by much!

David's commitment to submitting himself to authority was tested yet again. 1 Samuel 26:8-11 (NASB) *"Then Abishai said to David, 'Today God has delivered your enemy into your hand; now therefore, please let me strike him with the spear to the ground with one stroke, and I will not strike him the second time.' (9) But David said to Abishai, 'Do not destroy him, for who can stretch out his hand against the LORD'S anointed and be without guilt?' (10) David also said, 'As the LORD lives, surely the LORD will strike him, or his day will come that he dies, or he will go down into battle and perish. (11) 'The LORD forbid that I should stretch out my hand against the LORD'S anointed; but now please take the spear that is at his head and the jug of water, and let us go.'"*

David understood that the removal of Saul was the responsibility of the Lord, rather than his personal responsibility.

CONCLUSION:

Listen to the principles of submission to authority taught here: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- **No one can strike an authority figure without guilt...**
- **No one can strike an authority figure without penalty...**
- **No one has permission to kill an authority figure... (This would also pertain to usurping the influence of an authority through words and slander)**
- **God can cause an authority figure to die...**
- **God can allow an enemy to kill an authority figure...**
- **God can deal with an authority figure any way He pleases...**

Like David we must remember that **we are in subjection not to the person but to the anointing that is on the persons office.**

(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF LESSON) David so respected this, that later he

even had the man killed, that killed Saul. (2 Samuel 1:14-16)!

Submission is ours, authority is God's.